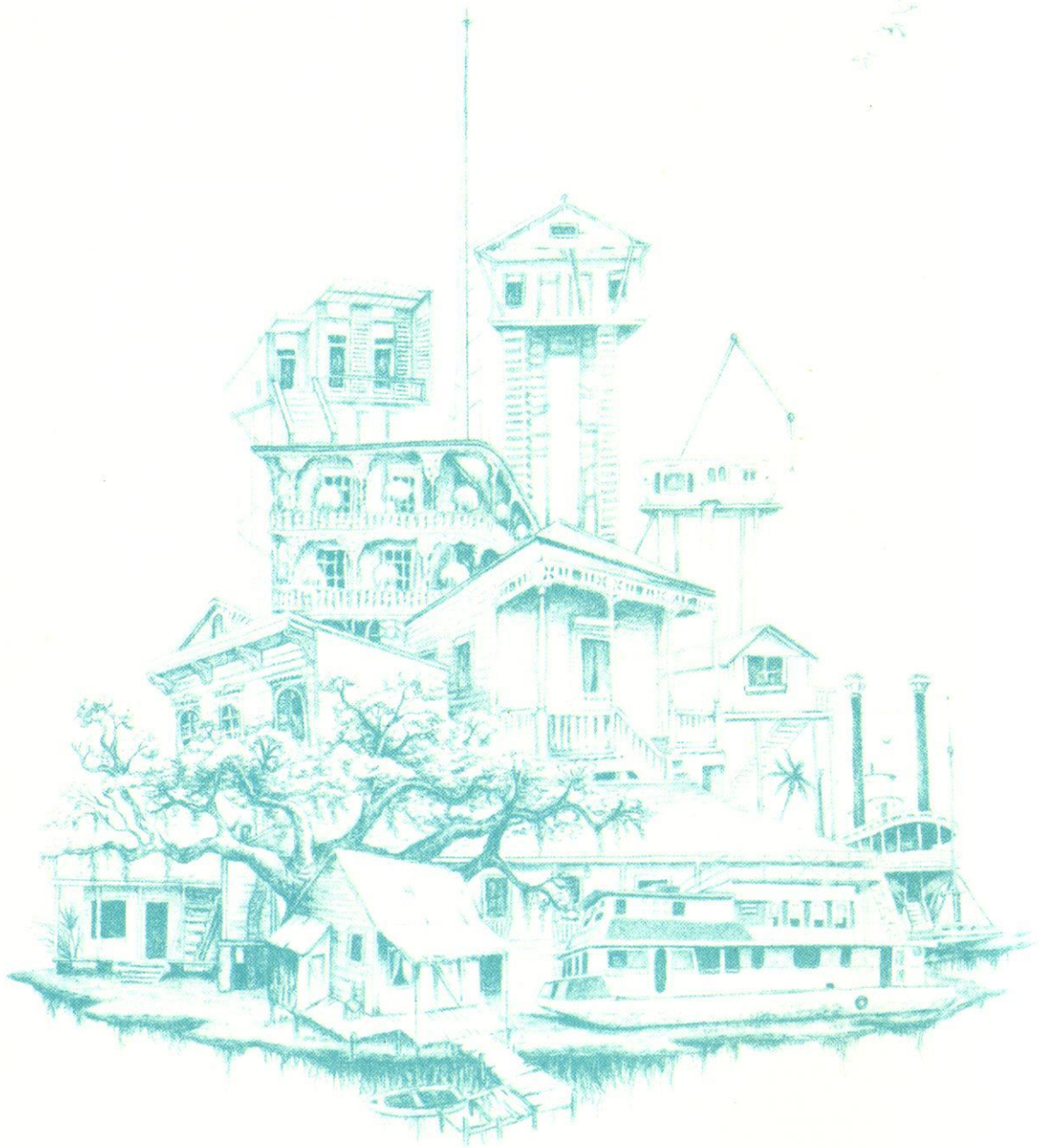
UNFATHOMABLE CITY





A New Orleans Atlas

BEING AN ATLAS IN TWENTY-TWO MAPS AND NEARLY THAT MANY ESSAYS ABOUT THE CITY THAT IS AT THE BOTTOM OF THE MISSISSIPPI DRAINAGE OF THE INTERIOR OF THE NORTH AMERICAN CONTINENT AND AT THE TOP OF THE GULF OF MEXICO AND AT THE CENTER OF THE AMERICAN UNCONSCIOUS, THE SMALL MORTAL CITY THAT IS THE IMMORTAL WELLSPRING OF MUCH POPULAR MUSIC AROUND THE WORLD, A CITY NOT QUITE THREE HUNDRED YEARS OLD, HALF OF THAT AN ERA OF SLAVERY, ALL OF THAT AN ERA OF STRIVING FOR FREEDOM; OF SEGREGATION AND MIXING; OF CRIME AND CORRUPTION IN SECRET AND OF THE CONFIDENT COLLECTIVE CELEBRATION IN THE STREETS THAT IS THEIR OPPOSITE; OF WILDLIFE FLYING OVER AND OIL PIPELINES CUTTING THROUGH; OF COMPLICATED STORIES, NOT ALL OF THEM IN BLACK AND WHITE; OF VARIOUS HEROINES, SOME HEROES; OF UNFINISHED TASKS AND INTERESTING POSSIBILITIES; A CITY RESTING ON THE PILLOWY SOFTNESS OF RIVER-DELIVERED MUCK, MUD, AND SOMETIMES THE HARD GROUND OF DISPUTED MEMORY; TO SAY NOTHING OF CRAWFISH BOILS AND THE SWEET LOUD SOUND OF BRASS BANDS

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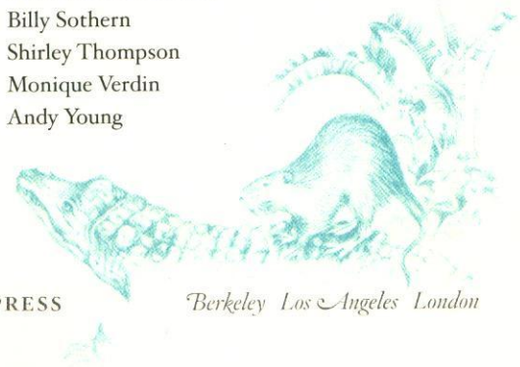
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The Line-Up

LIVE OAK CORRIDORS AND CARNIVAL PARADE ROUTES

Endymion
City Park
City Park Ave
Cemeteries
Metairie Rd
Canal St
N Carrollton Ave
Metairie Park
Earhart Expwy
Southport
Mid-City
S Jefferson Davis Pkwy
Tulane Ave
S Carrollton Ave
Gert Town
River Rd
Leonidas
S Claiborne Ave
Fontainebleau Dr
Vendome Pl
Carrollton
Audubon Blvd
Broadmoor
S Galvez St
Broadway St
Law Rd
Black Pearl
St Charles Ave
Nashville Ave
Crescent City, Rex
S Claiborne Ave
Hermes, Knights of Babylon, Knights of Chaos, Pygmalion, Tucks
Napoleon Ave
Carrollton, Iris
Carondelet St
Audubon Park
Uptown
State St
Jefferson Ave
Prytania St
Perrier St
Chestnut St
Camp St
Henry Clay Ave
Magazine St
King Arthur, Knights of Sparta, Oshun, Proteus
Thoth
Druids, Krewe d'Etat, Mid-City, Morpheus, Muses, Nyx, Okeanos
Tchoupitoulas St
Bacchus, Orpheus, Pontchartrain

Fairgrounds
Gentilly Blvd
N Broad St
St Bernard Ave
Elysian Fields Ave
St. Roch
St Roch Ave
Louisa St
Ursulines Ave
Bayou Rd
Seventh Ward
N Claiborne Ave
N Robertson St
Zulu
N Broad St
N Rocheblave St
Governor Nicholls St
Esplanade Ave
'tit Rex
Marigny
Spain St
Franklin Ave
St Claude Ave
N Dorgenois St
Orleans Ave
Treme
Barkus
Dauphine St
Royal St
Chartres St
Bienville Ave
Bienville St
Louis Armstrong Park
N Rampart St
Burgundy St
Bourbon St
Decatur St
Krewe Delusion
Krewe du Vieux
N Claiborne Ave
Crescent City
Tulane Ave
Canal St
Basin St
Toulouse St
St Ann St
St Peter St
French Quarter
Conti St
Iberville St
Common St
Krewe d'Etat, Mid-City, Proteus
Tucks
Knights of Babylon
Pontchartrain, Rex
Endymion
Knights of Chaos
Central Business District
Algiers Point
Earhart Blvd
Poydras St
Carrollton, Druids, Hermes, Iris, King Arthur, Knights of Sparta, Morpheus, Nyx, Okeanos, Oshun, Pygmalion, Thoth
Zulu
Jackson Ave
Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd
Julia St
Magazine St
Commerce St
Peters St
Convention Center Blvd
Chewbacchus
Central City
St Joseph St
Chewbacchus
Philip St
Simon Bolivar Ave
Muses
Prytania St
McDonogh
LaSalle St
Coliseum St
Camp St
Bacchus, Orpheus
Washington Ave
St Charles Ave
Garden District
Lower Garden District
Louisiana Ave
Irish Channel
Mississippi River
GRETNA
Huey P. Long Ave
Lafayette St
Franklin Ave

Live oak trees form a canopy over the middle of the street
Live oak trees line both sides of the street
Carnival krewe float parade routes
Beginning of float parade route
End of float parade route

13 THE LINE-UP

There are lines that divide and lines that connect, and New Orleans has plenty of both, from the canal that cuts off the city's eastern side to the streets where people promenade and stroll with an enthusiasm for pedestrian public space and mingling with strangers that is rare in America. What makes those streets beautiful, in many cases, are the avenues of broad-armed live oaks reaching toward each other from the sidewalks, as emblematic of the city as chestnuts are of Paris or palm trees of L.A. What makes the streets exuberant are the parades that roll through in Carnival season. These are two of the great life forces of the city, two lines that draw you out.

CARTOGRAPHY: SHIZUE SEIGEL ⚓ MAP APPEARS ON PAGES 92–93.

SENTINELS AND CELEBRANTS BY EVE ABRAMS

Once upon a time, New Orleans was covered in trees. The first thwack of progress came around 1718, when a French work gang, banished to the Louisiana wilderness as punishment for bootlegging salt, began clearing the land of cypress, willow, and palmettos. Cypress's oily heartwood, naturally resistant to insects and water, made for excellent planks, pilings, railroad ties, floors, doors, and shutters. Magnolia's bendable, white wood became tables, chairs, and dressers. But live oaks—the grand cultural and ecological icons of the South—were bound for the sea. Exceptionally dense and strong, and therefore difficult to form into planks, the curving branches of live oaks became the ribs and knees in ship hulls and, consequently, the victims of forest-wide decimation.

A hundred plus years later, once we had our city—as well as our houses, furniture, ships, and railroads—we found we needed something else in the blistery heat of New Orleans: shade. And who better to bring shade than live oaks?

Live oaks are massive, horizontally, with their roots below the earth as wide as their branches above. The canopy of a single mature tree easily spans 100 feet. More than one tree, and you have a corridor: the shaded stretch of North Dorgenois, with its magnificent, tumbledown houses and teens hanging on the corner; the upper stretch of Ursulines, where yellow-crowned night herons and monk parrots nest; the grand, lacy overhang on St. Charles, sheltering miles of mansions, streetcar lines, and grassy, picaresque neutral grounds. Step into a corridor's shade, and you are enclosed by nature in the midst of a city.

Some live oak corridors offer more than a woodsy overlay. During the final weeks of Carnival, Orleans, Napoleon, Jackson, Canal, and Magazine streets, and of course St. Charles Avenue, frame large sections of parades. Beneath their leaves and between their trunks, bands play, floats roll, trinkets are tossed, and people holler in expectation and delight. These corridors are not the only stretches of parade, but they are the finest: the intersection of two ecosystems, where the roots below steady the routes above.

It is impossible to explain Mardi Gras—a holiday I will boldly claim is bigger than Christmas. If you have not already done so, better just to come and live it. Float parades are but one part of Carnival, but like live oaks, they are an entire ecosystem: the field where fable, fantasy, wit, class, and hierarchy get played out, made fun of, and reified in the most flirty, dirty, fun, and perfectly family ways imaginable. Certain canopies bear permanent evidence of this overlapping ecosystem; their branches drip not only Spanish moss, but strings of beads that lose a bit of iridescence each time it rains.

Live oak branches on parade routes are trimmed at 17 feet from the ground in order to make way for the floats: giant satirical manifestations of politicians on the take, outsized high-heeled shoes, gargantuan alligators, jesters, and Greek gods. These huge electrified floats, fabricated throughout the year, pulled by tractors, and lit (somewhat) by flambeaux carriers, parade relentlessly on Saint Charles during Carnival season. Masked riders, mostly men, stand on the floats and throw petroleum-based, Made-in-China goodies (or hand-decorated shoes or coconuts) into crowds of clamoring hands.

Carnival is not exclusive to New Orleans. Cities and towns all over Louisiana, Alabama, the Caribbean, South and Central America, and Europe celebrate it. It's the same for live oaks: the New Orleans variety thrives across the Atlantic and the Gulf's coastal plains. "They're *so* southern," Coleen Perilloux Landry, the chairman and only human member of the Live Oak Society, drawls. She was speaking of the trees, not Carnival, but she could have been talking about both. Much grows in New Orleans, and we celebrate a great deal, but live oaks and Mardi Gras may well be the most illustrious examples.

Perhaps this is due to the completeness with which they take over a space. Stretches of New Orleans streets nest under cathedral-like tunnels, or *alleés,* created by the arcing, interweaving branches of a succession of live oaks. Turn into one of these extended canopies—on Washington, St. Roch, Gentilly, Jeff Davis, Bienville, Prytania, Louisiana, Carrollton, and Camp streets, arteries whose magnificence feels amplified by the arboreal surround—and the light and smell and sense of space are immediately altered. Massive branches hover and stretch overhead, weaving between neighboring trees and electrical lines, bending and dipping, forming an airy roof over asphalt, concrete, parked and moving cars. The light darkens, filters through the limbs, and descends in lacy patterns on the sidewalk. Below the earth, roots reach for one another, as if to hold hands, and interlock, stabilizing the entire corridor.

Parades alter the landscape seasonally, transforming streets into versions of themselves, cyclical personas they don for the holiday. Along with the floats, high school marching bands and assorted costumed revelers take center street. (Krewe of Rolling Elvi: I love you! 610 Stompers: I find your knee socks and dance moves utterly endearing.) Crowds gather on curbs, sidewalks, tree roots—often as close as possible to the floats (all the better for catching shiny throws). The entire length of the parade, friends and families mix and overlap, mirroring the intertwined branches above and roots below. Many stake out spots hours before; near a friend's bathroom or party is useful if you can swing it. Some families establish tidy compounds furnished with coolers, chairs, and stepladders on which kid-size seats have been installed. You can buy these in all the hardware stores Uptown, "or you can make one," explains Tom Snedeker, whose grandchildren sit tall behind him, hands outstretched, screaming for beads. In some sections of the parade—say, Napoleon or upper St. Charles—these mini-bleachers populated

by small children form a wall between sidewalk and curb, from one live oak to another. Personally, I like watching beneath the overpass on St. Charles. When the bands pass through, the sound of dozens of trumpets, tubas, trombones, and snare drums bounces against the metal and concrete. It makes a beautiful, life-affirming racket.

The parades are massive. The largest, Endymion, is about 3 miles long; others include thirteen to thirty floats, with marching bands (musicians, twirlers, flag corps, dance squads, cheerleaders, and the like) in between. By law, each parade must have at least seven marching bands; during Carnival season, "everyone loses weight," says Virgil Tiller, St. Augustine High School's band leader. Floats can be 30 to 350 feet long—which makes turning corners difficult. When floats break down or band members faint, gaps form. A parade's length expands and contracts as it rolls.

Generally speaking, live oaks only expand as they age (though during hurricanes, they do lose their leaves and, if necessary, their branches, in order to prevent themselves from falling over). Requirements for membership in the Live Oak Society are simple: a waistline of at least 8 feet and a human sponsor. Five hundred members of the society live in New Orleans; the oldest, McDonogh Oak, resides in City Park. McDonogh Oak is more than eight hundred years old, and its girth exceeds 24 feet. The president of the Live Oak Society, Seven Sisters Oak, lives two blocks from Lake Pontchartrain's North Shore. It's approximately twelve hundred years old and has a waistline of more than 38 feet.

St. Charles Avenue's first live oaks were likely planted after 1835, when the New Orleans and Carrollton Railroad Company laid down tracks through the plantations and farmland along the Mississippi River between Carrollton and the French Quarter. Residents and business owners sought shade for waiting passengers, who were also potential customers. "They wanted to outdo the merchants on Canal Street," Coleen Perilloux Landry explains. Some fifty years later, the asphalting of St. Charles was complete, and residents set about planting live oaks along their property lines. The city council followed suit, authorizing plantings on the neutral ground.

The trees on lower Esplanade's valley-like neutral ground aren't in orderly rows, and moving through them is reminiscent of a walk in the woods. These live oaks are among the oldest in the city, planted well over a century and a half ago. But double rows of trees were in New Orleans half a century before *that.* Prior to the Louisiana Purchase, during the Spanish colonial era, a double row of orange trees stood in front of the French Market. "New Orleans didn't have parks," explains historian John Magill, "so people were always looking for promenades."

In 1897, New Orleans suffered another yellow fever epidemic and began installing its first drainage, drinking, and waterworks systems. For the first time, neighborhoods grew lakeward, as opposed to along the river. A tremendous period of growth ensued under our longest-serving mayor, Martin Behrman, who was also an advocate of the City Beautiful Movement—a national reform philosophy that called for building cities with paved streets, trees, gardens, and big yards. The French Quarter, with its dense urban fabric, was considered a slum. The live oak canopies of Bienville, Banks, and Canal—now those were beautiful.

Business owners, residents, the city: everyone paid for and planted trees. In his 1903 inaugural speech as chairman of the Central Committee of Parks and Avenues (the predecessor to today's Department of Parks and Parkways), Allison Owen implored New Orleanians to plant trees in front of their own places. "The fact is we have been wasting time," he declared. "We are now beginning to do what we should have done years ago."

No wonder Owens felt an urgency: live oaks are slow. It can take twenty to thirty years before they develop a canopy. Yet once established, these grand trees feel timeless—omnipresent witnesses to generations of human lives. Parades keep time differently. They show up every twelve months to remind us another year has gone by.

New Orleans has other trees. Palms were all the rage in 1912; Ursulines and Jefferson were once lined with them (killed, sadly, in the punishing freeze of 1963). Sycamores, planted along Canal Street and in Jackson Square, were also popular, but they drop their leaves, and in time people found them a nuisance. Live oaks are more expensive than faster-growing crepe myrtles and magnolias, but "they make a real statement," says Skip Treme, former Parks and Parkways landscape architect. "When you plant a line of live oaks on a street," he explains, "it's the future you're thinking of." Of course, not everyone can afford to plant for the future. Depending on their height and girth, live oaks cost from hundreds to thousands of dollars.

But riding in a Carnival parade can be even more expensive. Fees vary by parade and by whether you must pay simply to ride or also for membership and/or your supply of beads. A thousand dollars is cheap; around three thousand—or more—is more like it. Who gets to ride has shifted over the past hundred years, and it's no longer necessary to be a white man (though being one still increases your options). According to Dannal Perry, riding is ridiculously fun. "You have never felt power until you're holding a coconut on a Zulu float," she says. "It's like holding the last scrap of bread on the planet."

Mardi Gras is wonderful. It is dressing up and wearing wigs and being what you're not. It is running into friends and meeting strangers and having unexpected conversations. But, of course, it is dark and horrible too. As historians have shown, many Carnival traditions are founded on racial exclusivity, secrecy, and maintaining a patriarchal social order. In these green times, the city no longer measures the success of Mardi Gras by the amount of garbage it generates, but up until quite recently, it did.

Some changes we facilitate; others we guard against. An article from the *Times Democrat,* published in January 1891, reports on the "outrage" committed by telephone company linemen who barbarously cut forty-one live oaks on a stretch of St. Charles. Mardi Gras was less than a month away, and the wires had to be raised to make way for the parade floats. Mayor Shakespeare, sick in bed, was called. Impeachment of the responsible officials was demanded.

New Orleans lost nearly 10 percent of its canopy in the months following Hurricane Katrina. We've planted more than ten thousand trees since, and recently, while I was following a parade under a young canopy on Martin Luther King, a cowboy named Lee Shezbie passed me on a brown and white thoroughbred. In the forest, an acorn falls where it may, but our urban canopy requires intention. Watching parades is what we do here. Best to do it in spaces where acorns have grown into live oak trees. ⚓